Writing accessible PDFs

A tagged PDF carries a logical structure beside its visual one, so assistive technology can read it in the right order.

What makes a document accessible

Marked content in the page stream is linked to structure elements through the parent tree. Reading order comes from the structure tree rather than from drawing order, and decoration such as rules and page furniture is marked as an artifact so it is skipped.

- Set the document language and title (/Lang, /Title, DisplayDocTitle).
- Mark every heading with H1 to H6 and keep the levels in order.
- Give each figure alternative text with /Alt.
- Use real table structure: Table, TR, TH with scope, TD.

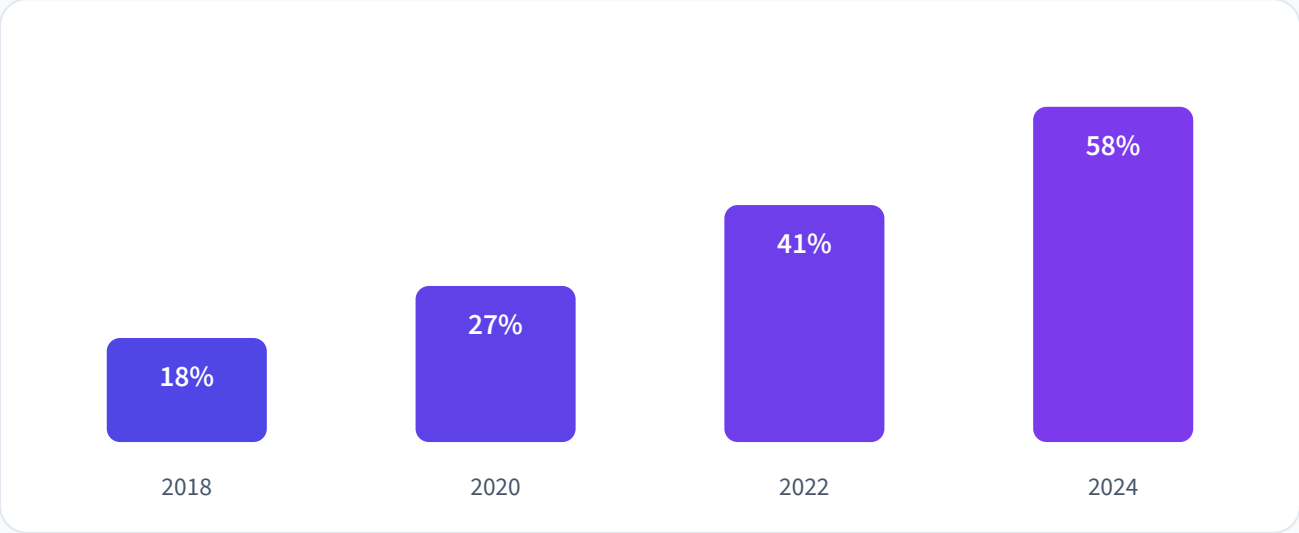


Figure 1. Illustrative share of tagged PDFs by year (sample data).

Structure types at a glance

Element	Purpose	Example
Document	Root of the tree	Whole file
H1 – H6	Headings	Chapter title
P	Paragraph	Body text
L / LI / LBody	Lists	Bullets
Figure	Images, charts	Chart with /Alt
Table / TR / TH / TD	Tabular data	This table
Artifact	Not content	Running header

Role mapping (/RoleMap) can alias custom tags onto the standard ones. Here, Callout maps to P.